

The Hidden Canadian Winners of the Data Centre Boom

Category: Spin-Off Industries & Employment | Evidence ID: #237

Archived: 2026-10-04 20:23

- **Original URL:** <https://ca.finance.yahoo.com/news/hidden-canadian-winners-data-centre-201000177.html>
 - **Research Category:** Spin-Off Industries & Employment
 - **Archival File:** 237_ca_finance_yahoo_com_news_hidden-canadian-winners-data-.pdf
 - **Extraction Status:** Full Web Transcript PDF
-

Source Content

The data centre boom has more winners than you think. Investors often look first at chips, servers, and power producers, and they're not wrong. But data centres also need land, industrial space, fibre networks, connectivity, and telecom infrastructure. That's where a few less obvious Canadian stocks start to look interesting. Dream Industrial REIT (TSX:DIR.UN), TELUS (TSX:T), and Quebecor (TSX:QBR.B) all give investors different ways to play the same long-term buildout. Each has an existing business that can stand on its own, with the data centre boom adding another layer of potential growth. DIR Dream Industrial REIT owns industrial and logistics properties across Canada, Europe, and the United States. Warehouses may not sound connected to artificial intelligence (AI) at first. But the physical footprint behind digital infrastructure keeps expanding. Cloud companies, hardware suppliers, logistics groups, and advanced manufacturers all need well-located industrial space. Dream's latest quarter showed a healthy operating base. Its Canadian portfolio reached 96.8% in-place and committed occupancy at the end of March 2026. Comparative-property net operating income rose 9% year over year. The real estate investment trust (REIT) also signed more than 1.8 million square feet of leases from January through April at a weighted average rent spread of 26.4% over prior or expiring rents. That gives investors a clear reason to watch the stock. Dream can benefit from strong industrial demand while paying a monthly distribution yielding 5% at writing and trading at 22 times earnings. The risk comes from debt, interest rates, and real estate values. REITs can feel pressure when financing costs rise. Still, Dream's industrial focus looks better positioned than many weaker property categories. TELUS gives investors a more direct digital infrastructure angle. The company runs one of Canada's major telecom networks, with wireless, internet, fibre, health, security, and digital services. Data centres need connectivity as much as they need electricity. AI workloads must move huge amounts of information between users, systems, clouds, and applications. TELUS has also stepped into AI infrastructure directly. In its Q1 2026 results, the company highlighted commercial success at its Sovereign AI Factories, with the Rimouski, Quebec facility sold out and a second facility launching in Kamloops, British Columbia. That's a useful sign that demand exists for Canadian-controlled AI computing infrastructure. The broader business remains under pressure, but the cash flow picture improved. TELUS reported free cash flow growth of 19% to \$583 million in the quarter. It also maintained its quarterly dividend at \$0.42 per share. That payout remains a major draw for income investors yielding 10.2% at writing while trading at 27.5 times earnings. The risk is debt. TELUS needs to keep lowering leverage while funding networks, dividends, and growth projects. Telecom competition also stays intense. But for investors seeking a dividend stock with AI infrastructure exposure, TELUS deserves a spot on the list. QBR Quebecor brings the other telecom

angle. Through Videotron and Freedom Mobile, it provides internet, mobile, wireline, business, and media services. This gives Quebecor exposure to connectivity demand, especially as businesses and consumers use more data. The company's latest quarter looked strong. Revenue rose 3.9% to \$1.40 billion, adjusted earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation and amortization (EBITDA) increased 4.9% to \$576.6 million, and adjusted net income climbed 18.6%. Quebecor also pays a quarterly dividend of \$0.40 per share, which now yields 2.4% at writing while trading at about 17.6 times earnings. Quebecor's data-centre connection is less direct than TELUS'. Its real strength sits in networks, mobile growth, and broadband demand. As data use rises, strong telecom infrastructure becomes more valuable. Businesses need reliable connections to cloud services, data platforms, and digital tools. Quebecor can benefit from that rising usage through its telecom base. Bottom line Dream Industrial, TELUS, and Quebecor won't grab the same attention as the biggest AI names. Yet all three are strong dividend providers even with just \$7,000 on hand to invest.

COMPANY	RECENT PRICE	NUMBER OF SHARES	ANNUAL DIVIDEND	ANNUAL TOTAL PAYOUT
FREQUENCY	\$13.94	502	\$0.70	\$351.40
TOTAL INVESTMENT	Monthly		\$6,997.88	T \$16.23
DIR.UN	431		\$1.67	
QBR.B	\$719.77	Quarterly	\$6,995.13	QBR.B \$67.31
104	\$1.60	\$166.40	Quarterly	\$7,000.24

Data centres need more than processors. These three Canadian stocks offer exposure to those less obvious parts of the boom, while still giving investors strong businesses, cash flow, and income along the way. Should you invest \$1,000 in Dream Industrial Real Estate Investment Trust right now? Before you buy stock in Dream Industrial Real Estate Investment Trust, consider this: The Motley Fool Canadateam has identified what they believe are the top 10 TSX stocks for 2026... and Dream Industrial Real Estate Investment Trust wasn't one of them. The 10 stocks that made the cut could potentially produce monster returns in the coming years. Consider MercadoLibre, which we first recommended on January 8, 2014 ... if you invested \$1,000 in the "eBay of Latin America" at the time of our recommendation, you'd have over \$16,000! *Now, it's worth noting Stock Advisor Canada's total average return is 91% – a market-crushing outperformance compared to 87%* for the S&P/TSX Composite Index.* Don't miss out on our top 10 stocks, available when you join our mailing list! Fool contributor Amy Legate-Wolfe has no position in any of the stocks mentioned. The Motley Fool recommends Dream Industrial Real Estate Investment Trust and TELUS. The Motley Fool has a disclosure policy.